

Søren Kierkegaard as Philosopher

Chapter IV: Søren Kierkegaard's Philosophy

A. Epistemology

Harald Høffding

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Søren Kierkegaard's Epistemology

1. When Kierkegaard considers the question of what knowledge an existing human being can attain, he is not thinking of every possible kind of knowledge, but only of what he calls *essential* knowledge, by which he means the knowledge that bears specifically on the knowing individual itself in its conditions of existence—ethico-religious knowledge. All other knowledge—empirical, mathematical, and historical—is a matter of indifference to him, because it has nothing to do with existence. Already here he makes a very important distinction, introduces an Either–Or. For it is surely a great question whether much of that knowledge he regards as indifferent is not—and has not been—of far-reaching significance for ethico-religious knowledge. When the latter is not the same at all times, this is due in part to that apparently “indifferent” knowledge, which consciously and unconsciously comes to exert influence even on those regions of spiritual life that one seeks to close off from it. But Kierkegaard simply takes the correctness of that distinction as given, and thereby marks off the boundary of his investigation.

2. The train of thought in Kierkegaard's epistemology is directed polemically both against Hegel and against those who (like Martensen) held that once one had placed oneself on the ground of faith and had one's consciousness reborn, one had thereby obtained the conditions for a higher, hitherto unattainable knowledge. Against Hegel it

is observed that he has not really answered Kant's objections to a knowledge of absolute reality. Thought cannot reach reality: for in the very moment it would have reached it, it has converted it into *thought* reality, or into possibility; thought cannot get beyond itself. Against speculative theology it is observed that faith has no interest in understanding itself in any way other than by continually remaining in the passion of faith. Of the highest things in the world one can only be knowing as a happy or as an unhappy lover; by approaching with speculative curiosity one in fact learns nothing. Take away the passion that is ever renewed by uncertainty as a salutary disciplinarian, and faith vanishes at once. The existing individual is always in the process of becoming, and time is never concluded; therefore full certainty can never be reached, and our knowledge can never get beyond approximations and hypotheses, with which in the domains of inessential knowledge we can also perfectly well content ourselves. But if the Eternal and Unconditioned is to be grasped and held fast, this can only happen in passion, because closure cannot be attained. The craving for something finished and concluded is of the Evil One, owing to indolence or impatience. We do not get beyond the eternal striving after truth.—Kierkegaard joins with enthusiasm Lessing's famous words: that if God held in his right hand all truth, and in his left the ever-living striving after truth, he would grasp the left hand, because eternal truth is not for a finite being. Lessing's justification for this choice is, however, somewhat different from Kierkegaard's. Lessing proceeds from the premise that it is not possession, but only acquisition, that gives a human being worth, inasmuch as one's powers are enlarged by seeking and one thereby grows in perfection. This is a more positive and psychological justification than the one we shall find in what follows from Kierkegaard, who is too much the ascetic and too preoccupied with preparing his doctrine of the Paradox to follow Lessing on his natural path.

More precisely, Kierkegaard's epistemology develops through the grounding of two propositions: a logical system can be given; but a system of existence cannot be given.

3. A logical system can be given. We can develop a coherent series of general determinations that hold for our thought. But here one must be careful not to smuggle in concepts that are drawn from reality. The logical system is a hypothesis whose validity for reality is problematic. And it must be investigated in particular whether we form this hypothesis after having come to know reality through experience, that is, as a kind of abbreviated expression (*Abbreviatur*) for it, or whether we form it independently of experience.—Kierkegaard expresses the wish to treat this last question more fully on another occasion; but it never happened. It is, as one easily sees, the question of whether the empiricist or the rationalist conception of the fundamental presuppositions

of thought is the correct one.

A peculiar difficulty in the construction of the logical system lies, for Kierkegaard, in how one can come to *begin* it, i.e. get hold of a starting point. For the simplest presuppositions are discovered by reflection, by going back from derived assumptions to the assumptions on which they rest—but when we have gone back far enough, how can we halt the reflection? It has just as little reason to halt at one point as at another, and will therefore, left to itself, continue indefinitely. Or, as it can also be expressed: doubt cannot halt itself. There must be a break, an arbitrary interruption. A decision must be made to halt the regressive chain of thought and to fix the point one has reached as the principle and starting point of the system. But what then becomes of presuppositionlessness? For the beginning of the logical system is then conditioned by something other than the logical, namely by that which causes me to make the decision!

“What if, instead of talking or dreaming about an absolute beginning, we were to speak of a *leap*?”

—Against Hegel, who wanted to give an absolute system of thought that closed upon itself like a circle, this line of reasoning by Kierkegaard is telling. If one compares it with the superficial catechism-talk with which Martensen “went beyond Hegel,” one has the difference between them as thinkers given in a single example.—Yet it is a question whether there is as great a difficulty about the “beginning” as Kierkegaard thinks. We do indeed find our ultimate presuppositions by reflection, or as Descartes expressed it, by doubt, or as one can perhaps best express it, by analysis. But in our search for presuppositions we always have a definite task in view, which is to be solved with the help of the presuppositions we seek. The task is to understand existence as given in experience, or some part of it. We therefore have a definite standard for how far we need to go—namely until we have found what is necessary for solving that task. If we can go still further, we discover more remotely situated presuppositions that present themselves with the same logical necessity as those first found; but for the time being there will be no use for these presuppositions. Perhaps advancing experience may lead us to make use of them.—It is therefore no arbitrary act that forms the beginning of logic, and its first principles have more than merely arbitrary validity.

4. A system of existence cannot be given. This is due, first, to the fact that all existence is in time, in the process of becoming. The latter point especially must not be forgotten. Speculative philosophy, which has claimed to explain everything, has forgotten that the one who constructs the speculative system, however insignificant he may be (“such a tiny little thingamajig as the existing Mr. Professor who writes the system”), still

himself belongs to the existence that is to be explained, and he is never finished with his own existence. The system would only become possible if one could look back on existence as concluded—but that would presuppose that one no longer existed! As we have already heard: life is lived forwards, but understood backwards.—And even that backward understanding, the insight into the necessity of past development, may rest on an illusion: for how can that which, so long as it is future, is only possible, become necessary by belonging to the past? Should the past be more necessary than the future? We understand the past properly only by making ourselves contemporaneous with it—but then we see it as becoming, not as concluded, and thus still for the most part merely as possible! (See on this point *Philosophical Fragments*.)

For the existing individual, moreover, thought and being are not one but separate. We think either back on what has been or forward to what will come. Simultaneity, absolute unity of thought and being, is impossible for an existing being, and exists only as a fantasy. There can be no continuity in our thinking, since it is continually interrupted by absorption in existence. All unity and continuity is only abstraction.

And finally: only the individual, the concrete, exists; to exist means to be individual. But only the universal and the abstract is the object of thought. Herein too lies a disproportion between thought and existence.

Because a system of existence cannot be formed by our thought, it does not follow, according to Kierkegaard, that such a system does not exist. A system of existence is given—but only for “one who is himself outside existence and yet in existence—who in his eternity is eternally concluded and yet includes existence within himself; that is, God.” (Since Kierkegaard defines existing as becoming, he consistently says: God does not exist, since He is eternal.)—But for human beings, existence is irrational, is a Paradox. The Paradox, the absurd and contradictory, is according to Kierkegaard no concession but is, as he puts it, an “ontological determination,” designating the relation between an existing knowing spirit and the eternal truth.

It must be admitted that a Paradox has been established through the sharp contradiction between the eternal truth (the eternal completedness of existence in God) and the existence that is constantly in the process of becoming. For how can, from any point of view whatsoever and for any thought of which we can form a concept, that which is constantly becoming stand as complete? Kierkegaard maintains firmly that “motion cannot be thought *sub specie aeterni*” [i.e. from the point of view of eternity, apart from time]; but how then can God be knowing about existence, about the whole of existence in its process of becoming, since indeed “existence cannot be thought without motion”?

—Here two thoughts have been violently yoked together, both of which Kierkegaard demands be held fast. Epistemology must surely here turn his favourite determination, Either–Or, against him and say: either the concept of the absolute system in God must be an illusion, or else the continual becoming must be a mere appearance.—Kierkegaard would not need, if he chose the first alternative, to give up his theistic presuppositions. Like other philosophical theists he could draw the consequence that God himself must be in the process of becoming, that God’s being is not concluded. This idea was developed simultaneously with Kierkegaard’s philosophical production by the true founder of modern philosophical theism, C. H. Weisse. Thereby the sharp antithesis would be resolved—but the absolutely concluded element in the idea of God would admittedly be sacrificed at the same time.—If one holds to the view that the existence we know unfolds in time, and that we cannot form any conception whatsoever of any other form of existence, then there is no question of a concluded system. But existence then becomes no Paradox either. It becomes irrational in the mathematical sense, inasmuch as only an approximate knowledge of it becomes possible. It stands before us like $\sqrt{2}$, which we can continually determine with more decimal places without exhausting it. Existence could be so rich and many-sided that there would be material enough in it for the most energetic and comprehensive thought we can conceive. But that is something entirely different from its being paradoxical, that is to say, from its presenting us with insurmountable contradictions. The inexhaustibility of existence for thought corresponds exactly to Lessing’s idea of the eternal striving after truth. If we hold fast to this idea, we must as its objective counterpart assume a continually becoming, and in its becoming un-surveillable, existence.

Kierkegaard proceeds from the premise that we cannot, even with respect to “essential” knowledge, content ourselves with approximations and hypotheses. But why ever not? Provided they are genuine approximations, and provided they are hypotheses that are increasingly verified by experience? Then we have reason enough not to abandon our hope of gaining clearer understanding and of being able practically to hold our own in the struggle with the world. And it is such a hope that sustains all our drive for knowledge.—But it will become apparent in what follows that Kierkegaard treats the concept of approximation in a remarkable way.

5. That the “essential” truth is paradoxical is grounded by Kierkegaard in the fact that the thought of God as the absolutely eternal must be held fast in the midst of the unceasing becoming of existence. On this depends also the fact that essential truth can be held fast only with the passion of faith.

If one asks how the idea of God arises for Kierkegaard, his answer is that God is a postulate, a last resort, without which we cannot endure to live. An image that would aptly express his thought would be the following: God is an anchor of distress that we need on the wild sea of existence, and at which, amid the surging waves, there is a constant tugging. We need an absolutely fixed point of support, a hook on which the chain of existence can be fastened, a point where the infinite reflection can find rest. But what is postulated is qualitatively different from the postulating being: not even the concept of existence is supposed to apply to God! God does not, according to Kierkegaard, stand in relation to the human being as a superlative ideal. "Between God and man there is an absolute difference"; "the qualities are absolutely different."—But then the situation is such that the last resort to which the human being in existence anxiously flies itself creates new difficulties and increases the suffering: for now the task is to unite the absolutely different qualities, to think them together! —Faith in God arises when the human being "with infinite interest inquires after a reality other than its own"—but thereby new problems are immediately posed.

One understands that Kierkegaard, given his conception, could not have it as easy as Martensen in building speculative theology on the ground of faith. This ground was of a volcanic nature, was in constant motion, just as it itself owed its origin to a revolution. Here there was neither time nor place to build, but only to struggle anxiously to preserve what already was.

An objective certainty, a confirmation by experience, can never be obtained. Not only is the future, as has often been remarked, ever equally uncertain, but when one contemplates nature in order to find confirmation of God's omnipotence and wisdom, one finds alongside traces in that direction also traces in the opposite direction. From objective uncertainty, then, we never escape—and since it is nevertheless a matter of life and death, this objective uncertainty is embraced with infinite passion. Truth can be held fast only in the form of subjectivity, as the object of personal feeling and passion.

6. After Kierkegaard has thus developed the claim that truth can be grasped and held fast only in a subjective, personal manner—that truth is subjectivity—he reverses the proposition and maintains: subjectivity is the truth. For only that which is grasped with subjective energy and passion can be the truth. If there are two people, one of whom prays in personal untruth to the true God, while the other "with the whole passion of infinity" prays to an idol, then the former in reality prays to an idol, while the latter truly prays to God. What matters first and foremost is a *how*, not a *what*; personal inwardness and energy, not the content to which this inwardness attaches itself. And with objective

uncertainty, with the contradiction that the content presents to the one who must hold fast to it in personal existence, inwardness and passion increase. Truth is a venture. To the proposition that subjectivity is the truth corresponds the other proposition that truth (objectively considered) is the Paradox.

With this famous proposition of his, that subjectivity is the truth, Kierkegaard has sharpened Lessing's proposition that only in eternal striving can one relate oneself to truth. The entire value is shifted from the objective (dogmatic) to the subjective (psychological) pole. The meaning is really this: only when truth is appropriated and held fast in personal feeling and striving does it have value. It is the personal nutritive value of truth that is decisive. The standard lies in the movement that is awakened in the inner life of the personality.

In fact, Søren Kierkegaard has in his own way stated the same thing that Ludwig Feuerbach had maintained a few years earlier in *The Essence of Christianity*: that theology is psychology. (*The Essence of Christianity* appeared in 1841, the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* in 1846. In this book, and already in *Stages on Life's Way*, Kierkegaard expressly refers to Feuerbach's interpretation of Christianity.) Only through an inconsistency can Kierkegaard demand a definite content, a definite objective faith, of subjectivity: the main thing is that it be in a state of truth-striving; what it relates itself to must be a matter of indifference. It must be the fullness and height of the personal life that matters, and it must provisionally remain an open question whether a certain definite dogmatic content of faith is necessary for the development of such a life.

But he does not draw the full consequence of his proposition. That would have led him to proclaim the principle of the free personality. He does not abandon the assumption of a standard for truth different from the personality itself, which for him is given in ecclesiastical dogmatics. And yet—on closer inspection (which we shall undertake when we have come to know his ethics) it will become apparent that this dogmatic guideline is not the ultimate one. He is too much a thinker to be able to rest content with it. His ultimate standard is of a formal nature: the relation to the dogmatic-ecclesiastical content of faith is for him the highest form of personal life, because in this relation the strongest contradiction, the greatest suffering and passion, comes forth in subjectivity. The last and decisive objection against him will then prove to be that he has torn the personality loose from the real, natural and social context in which alone its life can acquire a positive content. For only in the free subjectivity, struggling with reality and learning from reality, can truth dwell—not in the subjectivity that through formal, ascetic exercises torments itself into obedience to a content that is contrary to nature and hostile

to life.—But only through an examination of Kierkegaard's ethics can this point be more clearly illuminated.

What is great about Søren Kierkegaard's epistemology is the seriousness with which he grasps the connection of thought with personal life. There is something Greek in him. He wants to return from abstract thinking and contemplation to personal, existential thinking.

Our ideas all too easily become soldiers in peacetime. Søren Kierkegaard has led ideas forth from the comfort of contemplation to the strife and unrest of the struggle of life, and has pointed out the arena where the validity of "essential" knowledge must stand its test. Had the dogmatic impediment not been there, his thoughts would have attained a more directly universal significance; as it stands, a translation, a process of sifting, must take place before they can come to play the role for humanity that is rightfully theirs.